# COLOR CULTURE AND CHEMISTRY

## Kiln and Glaze Technology in Chinese Ceramics

Looking Guide

Lehigh University Art Galleries

*Spring 2026*

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Early Chinese pottery didn't use shiny glazes. Instead, artists decorated plain clay with carving, painting, and polishing. As technology improved, potters learned to control fire and air, creating darker or lighter clay colors for their depictions of animals and human figures.

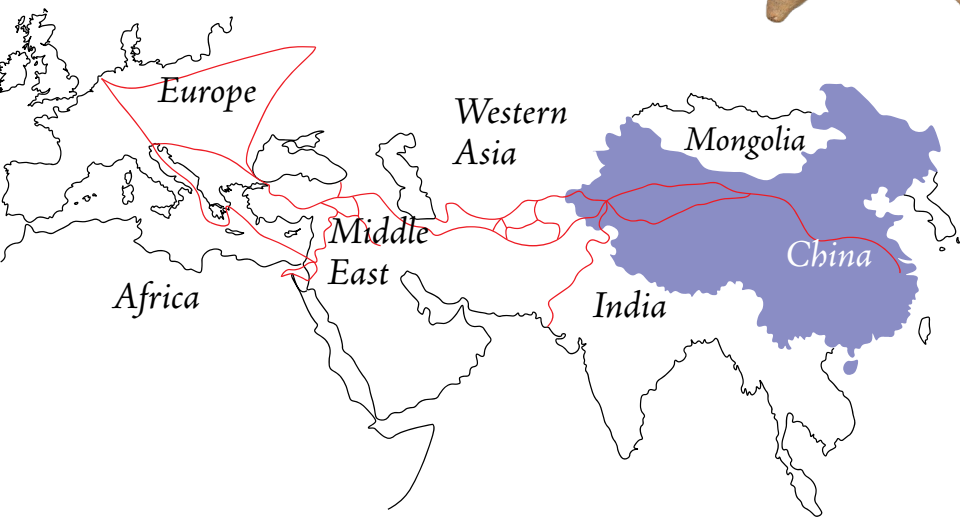
## COLORED GLAZES 5

New technology led to the invention of glazes, which made pottery shiny and colorful. Glazes are made from sand for gloss, clay for thickness, and minerals that help them melt onto the pot. Other minerals added color. In China, colors had special meanings linked to nature and values, so single-color (monochrome) ceramics became the true traditional style.

## INFLUENCES OF TRADE 7

Blue-and-white porcelain is not China's oldest tradition as most earlier ceramics were single-color. The blue-and-white style grew because of trade along the Silk Road, using cobalt from Persia and meeting strong demand from Europe. This led to mass production in China and later European copies like Dutch Delftware, showing how cultures influenced each other through art and trade.

## TRADE ROUTES






# EARLY DECORATION

唐
TANG
Dynasty

**Standing Courtesan**
*Tang Dynasty, 618 - 907 CE, China*

## Looking Prompts

Who do you think this person was?

Look at her hair and her posture?

Do you think she is a soldier?

A queen? A dancer? Why?

## A Closer Look

# EARLY DECORATION

漢
HAN
Dynasty

**Reclining Ram**
*Han Dynasty,*
*206 - 220 CE,*
*China*

## A Closer Look

## Looking Prompts

What animal is depicted in this piece?

What do you think was the purpose of this object?

If you could feel the object, what do you think it felt like?



# COLORED GLAZES

明
MING
Dynasty

**Vase with Ox blood glaze**
*Ming Dynasty ,*
*1462 - 1435 / 1644 - 1911 CE,*
*China*

## Looking Prompts

What colors do you see?

What natural elements could have been use to produce the color of the vase?

How is this vase different than Early Decoration ceramics?

## A Closer Look

# COLORED GLAZES

清
QING
Dynasty

**Brushpot with Tri-color underglaze**
*Qing Dynasty, K'ang-hsi period, 1663 - 1723 CE, China*

## A Closer Look

## Looking Prompts

How many different flowers can you count?

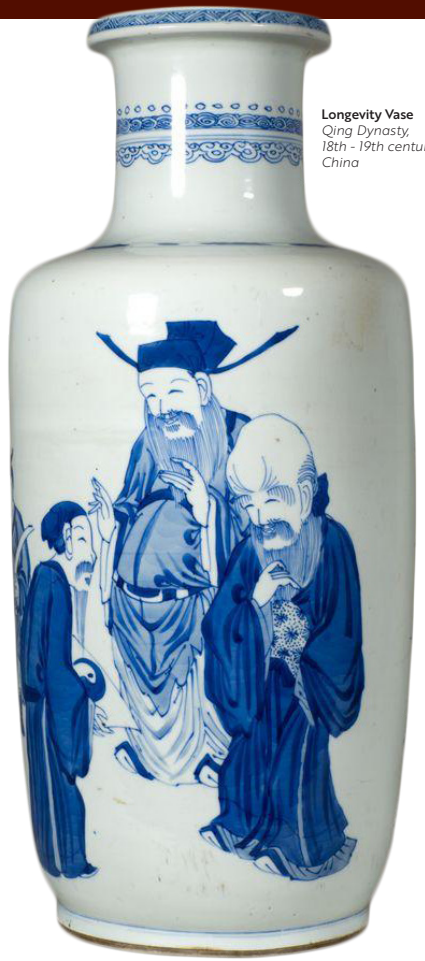
The red peonies are known as the "king" of flowers, what values might they represent?

How do you think heat might change the colors?



# INFLUENCE OF TRADE

清
QING
Dynasty



**Longevity Vase**
*Qing Dynasty, 18th - 19th century, China*

## Looking Prompts

What is the vase decorated with?

What could the text on the vase mean?

How is this vase different than traditional Chinese vases?

## A Closer Look

Scan to see
select 3D objects

Bloomberg Connects

Special Thanks to
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Designed by
*Ryan Javier '26*